

CT-268 PROFESSIONAL ETHICS

LECTURE 5

MORAL THEORIES:

VIRTUE ETHICS, SELF REALIZATION AND SELF INTEREST

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VIRTUE ETHICS

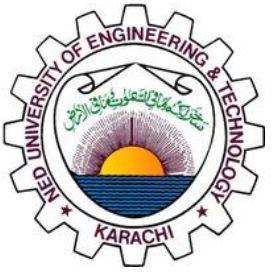
- Also known as **Aretaic Ethics** or **Teleology**.
- Virtue Ethics is a theory of morality that traces back to Ancient Greece.
- **Key Figures:** Socrates, Plato, and Aristotle — the trio of great ancient thinkers.
- Aristotle's Virtue Ethics differs from deontological or consequentialist theories; it focuses on character development rather than rules or outcomes.
- **Main Focus:**

What kind of person should I be, rather than what should I do.



Virtue as the Key to Happiness

- Virtue is essential for fulfilling the human purpose.
- **Definition of Virtue (*Arete*):** A trait or quality that enables a person to live in accordance with reason.
- Without virtue, one cannot achieve true happiness.
 - A virtuous life leads to eudaimonia (human flourishing, well-being, or living a life of excellence).
- Virtue Ethics emphasizes that actions alone are not enough — it is about developing a moral character over time.



- To understand the concept clearly, it helps to contrast it with our modern view of happiness:
 - **Modern Happiness (Hedonism):** Centered on feeling good, seeking pleasure, and avoiding pain. It is subjective and can change from hour to hour.
 - **Eudaimonia:** Centered on *doing* good and being a person of strong moral character. It is an objective measure of how well a person has lived out their human potential.

Virtue as Moderation (The Doctrine of the Mean)



- **Virtue is the Mean:** The right balance between two extremes (deficiency and excess).
- Examples:
 - Courage is the mean between cowardice and recklessness.
 - Generosity is the mean between stinginess and extravagance.
 - Friendliness is the mean between grouchiness and obsequiousness.



Types of Virtue

- **Moral Virtue:** Formed through habit and practice (e.g., courage, generosity, temperance).
- Moral Virtues concern actions and emotions.
- **Intellectual Virtue:** Developed through instruction and learning (e.g., wisdom, prudence).
- Intellectual Virtues relate to reasoning and knowledge.



Virtue as Character

- **Virtue is a Habit:** It is developed over time through repeated actions.
- Virtue is not just about specific actions, but about building a moral character.
- A person's character shapes how they will act in any given situation.
- Example: A courageous person consistently makes brave decisions, not just once.



Rationality and Moral Choice

- Reason is the key to finding the mean between extremes.
- A virtuous person uses reason to guide their actions and emotions.
- The mean varies depending on the individual and the situation.
- Morality is thus a practical endeavor — it requires discernment and adaptation.



The Ultimate Goal: Eudaimonia

- Eudaimonia is the state of living a good, fulfilled life.
- It is not merely subjective pleasure, but a life lived in accordance with reason and virtue.
- Aristotle asserts that only rational beings (humans) can achieve eudaimonia.
- It is a lifelong pursuit, not something that can be achieved quickly or through singular acts.



Virtue Ethics in Action

- **Virtue Ethics emphasizes moral education:** Teaching individuals to cultivate virtuous habits from a young age.
- It focuses on developing character over time rather than following strict rules.
- **Practical application:** In modern times, Virtue Ethics can guide personal decisions, leadership, and ethical business practices.



Strengths of Virtue Ethics

- **Focus on Character Development:** Virtue Ethics emphasizes the importance of moral character, encouraging individuals to cultivate virtues like courage, generosity, and wisdom over time. This long-term perspective helps people become morally better individuals rather than just focusing on individual actions.
- **Holistic Approach to Ethics:** Unlike rule-based ethics (like deontology) or consequence-based ethics (like utilitarianism), Virtue Ethics considers the entirety of a person's life and moral development. It looks at what makes a person good, not just their actions in isolated situations.
- **Flexibility and Adaptability:** By emphasizing the "mean" between extremes (e.g., courage is between recklessness and cowardice), Virtue Ethics is flexible and allows for context-specific judgments. This flexibility enables individuals to make decisions based on circumstances, not rigid rules.
- **Practical Application:** Virtue Ethics provides practical guidance for real-life decision-making, as it encourages people to act with reason and moderation in their personal and professional lives. It applies to various contexts, including education, business, and leadership.



Weaknesses of Virtue Ethics

- **Lack of Clear Action Guidelines:** Offers no concrete rules or direct instructions (such as "do not lie") for deciding what to do in specific, complex situations.
- **Cultural Relativism:** Ideas of what constitutes a virtue vary across different cultures and societies, making it hard to apply universally.
- **Overlooks Duty and Consequences:** Focuses so heavily on the actor's character that it downplays the importance of predictable outcomes or moral duties.
- **Difficult to Teach and Assess:** Building character traits takes time and is far harder to measure, teach, or evaluate than simply following a set of rules.

Scenario 1: The Open-Source "Shortcut"



- **The Situation:** You are working on a high-stakes, time-sensitive software engineering team project. Your feature is lagging behind, and the deadline is tonight. You find a perfectly functional, complex block of code on GitHub that solves your exact problem. The license requires attribution, but your professor's syllabus strictly states that all submitted code must be entirely original. If you copy-paste it and tweak the variable names, no automated plagiarism checker will catch it.
- **The Virtue Focus:** Integrity.
- **The Aretaic Reflection:** A virtue ethicist would not just ask if they would get caught (consequentialism) or look purely at the syllabus rule (deontology). They would ask: "Am I becoming a *competent, trustworthy* engineer if my default response to pressure is deception? What habit am I building for when I face tight deadlines in the tech industry?"
- **The Virtuous Action:** Communicating transparently with the team and professor about the delay, accepting a lower grade if necessary, and prioritizing the actual acquisition of competence over a superficial metric of success.

Scenario 2: The "harmless" Data Analytics Pipeline



- **The Situation:** You are doing an internship at a tech startup. Your supervisor asks you to build a data scraper and analytics pipeline for a new app. While configuring the database, you realize the app logs precise user location data 24/7—even when users have chosen "Only while using the app" in the UI. When you bring it up to your supervisor, they laugh it off and say, "Don't worry about it, it is a known bug we will fix in a later sprint. Just focus on optimizing the pipeline query speeds for now."
- **The Virtue Focus:** Courage.
- **The Aretaic Reflection:** Virtue ethics centers on *phronesis* (practical wisdom). You must weigh respect for your supervisor against your responsibility to the public. Am I practicing the virtue of *courage* by speaking up, or am I slipping into cowardice and complacency by staying silent because it's comfortable?
- **The Virtuous Action:** Documenting the issue formally, firmly re-addressing the ethical risks with your supervisor, or escalating it if necessary. A virtuous engineer refuses to habituate themselves into ignoring systemic flaws that exploit others.



SELF-REALIZATION

- Its being able to reach heights that you never believed you could.
- Self realization helps us in gaining control over our life.
- **Types:** Self realization can have many different meanings.
 - **Over time changes in emotional/physical views of oneself:** Many events over time provide evidence of a characteristics in oneself.
 - **Immediate instances of change due to single events:** When one single specific event changes the person(s).
 - **Group change:** When the same events change a group of people, maybe similarly or differently. Not everyone reacts the same to it, and 'it' can be several events, or just simply one.



Benefits of Self Realization

- **Being at peace with yourself:** The better you know yourself, the easier it is to find what you like, and how you fill your empty spaces.
- **It helps get rid of bad thoughts:** You can be happy in having that feeling of knowing, and not having to contemplate decisions you don't want to make.



Self Realization vs Maturity

- **Maturity:** The state, fact, or period of being mature.
- **Mature:** Complete in natural growth or development.
- Self realization is a *factor* to maturity.
 - Helps you mature, as you learn more about yourself and what you do in certain situations.
 - Not only learning about yourself, but others around you as well.

Scenario 1: The "Easy A" vs. The Imposter Syndrome



- **The Situation:** You need to pick a technical elective for your final year. Option A is "Intro to Web Scripting," a class you already basically know from your hobbies. It guarantees a flawless A and a boosted GPA with almost zero effort. Option B is "Advanced Simulations," a difficult, mathematically intense class. You are fascinated by the topic, but terrified you will struggle, look stupid, and risk dropping your GPA.
- **The Virtue Focus:** Magnanimity (Greatness of Soul).
- **The Self-Realization Angle:** Aristotle spoke of magnanimity; the virtue of knowing your worth and aiming for great things worthy of your potential. Choosing Option A is the vice of pusillanimity (smallness of soul), where you hide in your comfort zone out of fear. Self-realization requires pushing the boundaries of your intellect.
- **The Virtuous Choice:** Choosing Option B. You recognize that the purpose of your education is not a transactional GPA score (external good), but the expansion of your own capabilities and the mastery of your craft (internal good).

Scenario 2: The Mid-Degree Existential Crisis (Purpose)



- **The Situation:** You entered Computer Science because you love logic and puzzles. By your junior year, you realize the recruitment pipeline is heavily steering you toward optimizing ad-revenue algorithms or high-frequency trading platforms for massive corporations. You feel an existential emptiness; you are highly skilled, but the actual application of those skills feels empty and unaligned with your values.
- **The Virtue Focus:** Phronesis (Practical Wisdom).
- **The Self-Realization Angle:** Self-realization means aligning your techne (technical skill) with your telos (ultimate purpose). Practical wisdom allows you to look at your skill set and ask: "How do I deploy my unique talents to live a meaningful life that contributes to human flourishing?"
- **The Virtuous Choice:** Active self-reflection and pivot. Instead of mindlessly following the campus recruiting conveyor belt, you use your coding skills for open-source humanitarian tools, tech-policy research, accessibility software, or local community projects. You realize that your fulfillment comes from using your intellect to solve problems that actually matter to you.



SELF INTEREST

- Self-interest generally refers to a focus on the needs or desires (interests) of the self.
- A number of philosophical, psychological, and biological theories examine the role of self interest in motivating human action.
- It can influence one's decision while making a choice.
- As a professional, a healthy amount of self interest is essential for survival but if it increases, professional ego will be the result.



In Philosophy

- **Enlightened self-interest**, a philosophy which states that acting to further the interests of others also serves one's own self-interest.
- **Ethical egoism**, the ethical position that moral agents ought to do what is in their own self-interest.
- **Hedonism**, the school of ethics which argues that pleasure is the only intrinsic good.
- **Rational egoism**, the position that all rational actions are those done in one's self-interest.



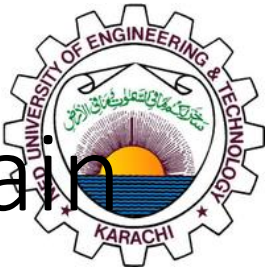
In Psychology

- Psychological concepts concerned with self-interest include psychological egoism, the view that humans are always motivated by self-interest and narcissism, which is an unhealthy self-absorption due to a disturbance in the sense of self.
- In Biology,
- In Richard Dawkins' book *The Selfish Gene*, self-interest concept was concerned as one of the artefact in evolution process among all alive organisms.



Scenario 1: The Group Project Carry

- **The Situation:** You are paired with three struggling classmates for a major software architecture project. You realize it would take you 10 hours of intense effort to teach them how to implement the repository pattern correctly, but only 3 hours to just write the whole codebase yourself and put all your names on it. You are tempted to freeze them out, do all the work alone, and secure your guaranteed "A" while saving yourself 7 hours of frustration.
- **The Virtue Focus:** Patience, Leadership, & Enlightened Self-Interest.
- **The Self-Interest Reflection:** Narrow self-interest says: Save the 7 hours and do it alone. However, virtue ethics asks you to consider your long-term professional character. If you freeze them out, you habituate yourself into being a poor collaborator who cannot lead, mentor, or delegate skills that are vital for moving up from a junior dev to a tech lead.
- **The Virtuous Choice:** Investing the time to mentor your teammates. Your true self-interest is served not just by the short-term grade, but by developing the management and communication virtues that will make you a highly valued engineering leader in the future.



Scenario 2: The Campus Tech-Club Brain Drain

- **The Situation:** You spent two years climbing the ranks of the university's competitive web development club, and you just got elected as President. Two weeks later, you land a lucrative, dream summer internship at a major tech company. Suddenly, running the student club feels like a massive chore that won't add anything new to your resume. You are tempted to checked out mentally, do the absolute bare minimum to keep the club afloat, and focus 100% of your energy on pre-studying for your internship.
- **The Virtue Focus:** Fidelity (Loyalty), Magnanimity, & Responsibility.
- **The Self-Interest Reflection:** Short-term self-interest tells you to abandon the club because you already "got what you needed" from it. But virtue ethics emphasizes that a person of excellent character honors commitments. Walking away teaches you to treat communities purely in terms of transaction, extracting value and leaving them hollow.
- **The Virtuous Choice:** Honoring your role by restructuring the club's leadership, setting up a solid transition plan, and delegating effectively. This serves your true self-interest by proving you are someone who leaves organizations better than they found them, earning you lifelong respect and a strong network.

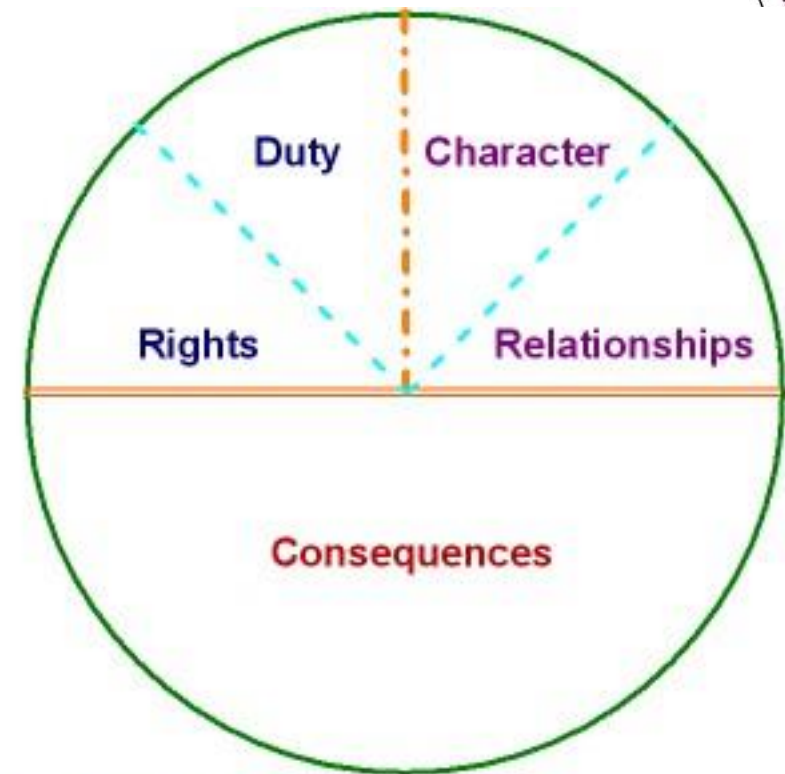


Ethical Reasoning

Deontological: Taking the Right Action

Teleological: Being Good Persons

Consequential: Predicting the Best Possible Future



Ethical Reasoning

Duty and Rights - Taking the Right Action

Character and Relationships - Being Good Persons

Consequences - Predicting the Best Possible Outcome



Come up with a few examples!

